Decoding ISO 9001 2026 Clause 7 Support

People infrastructure measurement knowledge and controlled information



Establish the capability needed for correct work rather than relying on evidence of purchase or attendance.

Expanded practitioner edition for IMS managers, engineers and leadership teams

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Using this publication

Establish the capability needed for correct work rather than relying on evidence of purchase or attendance.

This expanded practitioner edition explains every numbered subclause within Clause 7 of the supplied ISO 9001:2026 text. It develops the earlier RPG collected technical insights into a standalone working guide with operational examples, role applications, two reusable worksheets and two printable poster annexes.

Requirements and recommendations

The required outcomes are original paraphrases of the supplied standard. Its informative Annex A clarifies meaning without adding requirements. Practical methods, scenarios, sample sizes, worksheet fields, review periods and poster prompts in this book are RPG recommendations, unless a requirement is expressly identified. Use a licensed copy for the complete normative text. [1]

How to read it

Begin with the working language and coverage route. Read the relevant clause interpretation, then follow one real process with its owner. Use the cases to challenge your reasoning and the worksheets to record a decision. The annexes can support team discussion; they are not exhaustive audit checklists.

Technical basis

Supporting referrals were checked against official public publication records on 8 November 2026. Many APG papers and ISO/TS 9002:2016 address the earlier edition. Use them only where consistent with the 2026 requirement. ISO 9000 supplies the normative vocabulary referral. Other supporting publications do not automatically expand ISO 9001 requirements.

All organisations, events and figures in the cases are fictional teaching examples. They are not customer results, statistical benchmarks or promised savings. Photographs are illustrative. This guide does not establish certification or replace applicable technical, contractual or legal assessment.

Working language and practical translation

These are plain English working explanations, not formal quotations or replacements for ISO 9000 definitions. The application column shows the decision each term should help a reader make.

Term	Working explanation	Practical translation
Competence	Ability to apply relevant knowledge and skills to the task.	Evaluate task performance rather than attendance alone.
Awareness	Understanding the significance of one’s contribution and decisions.	Ask what happens when a requirement cannot be met.
Calibration	Establishing the measurement relationship under stated conditions.	Review what the result means for the intended use.
Verification	Confirmation that specified requirements have been fulfilled.	Identify the requirement and suitable evidence.
Knowledge	What the organisation needs to understand and apply to operate effectively.	Test use of knowledge, not simply storage.
Documented information	Information the system needs to control, use or preserve as evidence.	Consider availability, suitability, protection and history.

Read the verbs carefully

A requirement calls for fulfilment. Guidance suggests a possible approach. Thinking about an issue differs from incorporating it into a decision. Suitability depends on the organisation’s context, while applicability concerns whether a requirement is relevant to the situation. The supplied Annex A.2 and the vocabulary referrals help resolve these distinctions. [1]

Do not turn a preferred template, score or software workflow into a requirement simply because it is familiar. Equally, do not use flexible wording to avoid an outcome the standard actually requires.

Clause coverage and reading route

The references below cover every numbered subclause within this book’s main clause. Where related subclauses share a page, their required outcomes are distinguished in the text. Parent headings organise the requirements and are included in this coverage.

Covered references	Interpretation section
7.1, 7.1.1, 7.1.2	7.1.1 and 7.1.2 Resources and people
7.1.3, 7.1.4	7.1.3 and 7.1.4 Infrastructure and operating conditions
7.1.5, 7.1.5.1, 7.1.5.2	7.1.5 Measurement fitness and traceability
7.1.6	7.1.6 Knowledge that can be applied
7.2	7.2 Competence and evidence of effectiveness
7.3, 7.4	7.3 and 7.4 Awareness and purposeful communication
7.5, 7.5.1, 7.5.2	7.5.1 and 7.5.2 Create information people can use
7.5.3, 7.5.3.1, 7.5.3.2	7.5.3 Control availability integrity and history

The question to carry through the book

Could the authorised person perform the actual task correctly with the resources available today?

Read across the system

Clause interpretation supports a working process. It does not require the organisation’s manuals, software modules or department structure to mirror the numbering of the standard. The links to other clauses in this book help preserve that systems perspective. [1, A.1, A.2]

7.1.1 and 7.1.2 Resources and people

Required outcome

Under 7.1.1, determine and provide the resources required to establish, operate, maintain and improve the QMS, considering internal capability and constraints and what must be obtained externally. Under 7.1.2, provide the people necessary for effective implementation and the operation and control of processes. [1]

Practical translation

The resource decision concerns usable capability. A nominal headcount does not establish the availability of competent people at the time, location and workload at which they are needed. External provision can help, but the associated controls and interfaces remain important.

Application in the work

An engineering service forecasts more complex reviews. Consider the work profile, competence, absence cover, supervision and supporting information. Compare the approved commitments with usable capacity before accepting additional work. A capacity model is an RPG planning aid rather than a mandatory ISO format.

Evidence and judgement

Sample a normal shift and a foreseeable constraint. Can the allocated people complete the control as intended? Review unresolved workload, queues and external support arrangements alongside approved resource decisions. Relate the result to conformity and customer satisfaction rather than only utilisation.

Avoid this mistake

ISO 9001 does not prescribe a universal staffing ratio. Working overtime is not automatically proof of nonconformity, but a known inability to operate a required control cannot be resolved by a headcount statement alone.

Guidance referral

A.7.1.1 and A.7.1.2 explain capability and people considerations. ISO 10015:2019 supports competence development; it does not determine staffing numbers. [4]

7.1.3 and 7.1.4 Infrastructure and operating conditions

Required outcome

Determine, provide and maintain the infrastructure and the environment needed to operate processes and achieve conforming outputs. Infrastructure can support work on site, remotely or through a combination. The operating environment can involve relevant physical, social and psychological factors. The notes give examples; they do not require every listed factor to have a separate programme. [1]

Practical translation

Infrastructure concerns the enabling assets and systems. The environment concerns the conditions under which the work occurs. A remote technical reviewer may need suitable software and secure access, together with a setting in which the critical review can be performed reliably.

Application in the work

For a measuring room, examine stability, suitable equipment, software version and the effect of interruption on a judgement. For remote service, check access to controlled information, communication resilience and practical working conditions. The QMS assessment considers their effect on conformity; other management systems may impose additional duties.

Evidence and judgement

Follow one infrastructure failure into the affected work and response. Review maintenance, service availability, conditions at the point of use and decisions when a resource is unavailable. A named maintenance owner and restoration criterion are useful implementation choices.

Avoid this mistake

A current maintenance plan does not prove that a specific resource is suitable or functioning. ISO 9001 does not automatically prescribe a particular building standard, remote work policy or environmental management system.

Guidance referral

A.7.1.3 and A.7.1.4 explain changing working arrangements and interfaces with other disciplines. Use the controlled criteria relevant to the actual process.

7.1.5 Measurement fitness and traceability

Required outcome

Under 7.1.5.1, provide suitable monitoring and measurement resources where results verify conformity. Maintain continuing fitness and keep appropriate documented evidence of suitability. Under 7.1.5.2, where traceability is required or essential to confidence, calibrate, verify or both at defined intervals or before use against suitable traceable standards. Where such standards do not exist, document the basis. Identify status and protect equipment from invalidating adjustment, damage or deterioration. Assess previous results when equipment is found unsuitable and act where necessary. [1]

Practical translation

A calibration certificate establishes information about the instrument under its calibration conditions. The user must still decide whether the measurement process is fit for the task. Range, resolution, method, uncertainty, environment and acceptance criteria can matter. These considerations should be technically appropriate, not applied through an arbitrary universal rule.

Application in the work

A gauge fails a subsequent check. Identify the potentially affected work since the last defensible assurance point. Investigate the nature and magnitude of the error, relevant tolerance and other evidence. Stop unsupported use, establish suitable replacement capability and decide what earlier results or released outputs require review.

Evidence and judgement

Examine the certificate, result review, equipment identity, interval basis and actual use. Check that uncertainty or an out of tolerance result has not been ignored. The interval and retrospective assessment should be supported by competent judgement; the clause does not prescribe one year for every instrument.

Avoid this mistake

A calibration label is not a complete suitability decision. Nor does the clause require every item of equipment to be calibrated or every calibration provider to hold accreditation solely because ISO 9001 is used. Other requirements may impose more specific conditions.

Guidance referral

A.7.1.5 clarifies monitoring and measurement. ISO 10012:2026 provides a separate measurement management framework, not an automatic extension of ISO 9001 certification criteria. [5]

7.1.6 Knowledge that can be applied

Required outcome

Determine the knowledge necessary for process operation and intended QMS results. Retain, apply and share it to the extent needed. When requirements or trends change, assess existing knowledge and obtain or access the additional knowledge and updates required. [1, A.7.1.6]

Practical translation

Knowledge can reside in people, methods, experience and systems. A file archive may preserve information without enabling a person to use it. The test is whether the organisation can apply what it needs when performing the work.

Application in the work

A specialist is retiring. Identify the judgements that depend on that person, including unusual failure signatures and the reasons behind acceptance rules. Use observed practice, case discussion and controlled technical guidance to transfer relevant knowledge. Confirm that the recipient can use it, not merely find the folder.

Evidence and judgement

Choose a consequential task and ask another authorised person to explain the method, decision boundaries and escalation route. Review how lessons from faults, changed requirements and provider experience reach that task. Evidence of application can include a technically justified review or an appropriate response to an exception.

Avoid this mistake

Recording every conversation is not required. A knowledge database or artificial intelligence tool does not establish that the retained material is correct, current or appropriately applied. Protect access and technical judgement where they matter.

Guidance referral

A.7.1.6 gives explanatory context. ISO 30401:2018 is a separate knowledge management standard; consult its amendments and current status if adopting it. [7]

7.2 Competence and evidence of effectiveness

Required outcome

Define the competence needed by people whose work under the organisation’s control affects QMS performance. Ensure suitable competence through education, training or experience. Where action is needed to develop competence, evaluate that action’s effectiveness. Keep appropriate documented evidence of competence. [1, A.7.2]

Practical translation

Attendance is evidence that someone attended. Competence concerns whether the person can perform the relevant work with the required result. An assessment should reflect the task and its consequences, including the recognition of limits and when to seek help.

Application in the work

For a technical reviewer, specify the type of work, decision authority and unusual conditions they must recognise. Development might include mentoring, supervised work and assessment against representative examples. A training course can contribute without being the whole authorisation basis.

Evidence and judgement

Trace a competence requirement to the person’s evidence and authorised task. Sample a difficult decision and check the applicable limits. Evaluate whether development actions changed task capability. A competence matrix is useful where it helps allocate the right person, but the matrix itself does not establish ability.

Avoid this mistake

ISO 9001 does not require every person to hold an external qualification. Nor does experience alone prove current competence for every changed task. Customer, legal or technical requirements may impose specific qualifications.

Guidance referral

A.7.2 explains competence in context. ISO 10015:2019 offers optional guidance for competence management and people development. [4]

7.3 and 7.4 Awareness and purposeful communication

Required outcome

Under 7.3, people working under organisational control need awareness of the quality policy, relevant objectives, their contribution and its benefits, the consequences of nonconformity, and quality culture and ethical behaviour. Under 7.4, determine relevant internal and external communications, covering subject, timing, audience, method and responsibility. [1]

Practical translation

Awareness concerns understanding the significance of the work. Communication concerns getting suitable information to the right recipient at the right time. Sending a message is not the same as establishing the understanding needed for a consequential action.

Application in the work

A changed acceptance rule affects a contractor and two shifts. Decide who must know before the next job, the effective revision, how understanding will be checked and what happens to work already in progress. Explain the customer consequence of using the wrong criterion rather than requesting an unexplained acknowledgement.

Evidence and judgement

Ask people how they would respond to an unclear requirement or suspect result. Compare answers with the approved route and observe whether external parties receive the information they need. A practical communication record can preserve ownership and the relevant decision without requiring a signature for every exchange.

Avoid this mistake

The standard does not mandate a communication matrix or annual awareness presentation. Posting the policy online does not demonstrate understanding. The inclusion of culture and ethics should influence real conduct rather than simply add more training slides.

Guidance referral

A.7.3 and A.7.4 clarify awareness and different forms of communication. ISO 10018:2020 is an optional referral for engagement. [8]

7.5.1 and 7.5.2 Create information people can use

Required outcome

Under 7.5.1, include the documented information ISO 9001 requires and what the organisation determines necessary for QMS effectiveness. Under 7.5.2, when creating or updating it, establish suitable identification and description, format and medium, and review and approval for suitability and adequacy. [1]

Practical translation

The question is whether information is adequate for its users and purpose. A controlled instruction should identify the right activity and explain the information needed to perform it correctly. An electronic workflow can be documented information just as a paper instruction can.

Application in the work

An engineer changes an acceptance rule. The review should consider technical adequacy, the people who use the rule, linked forms and digital logic, and any language or presentation needs. Issue the correct approved version before it becomes operative. Plain language and usable illustrations can reduce ambiguity without altering the technical criterion.

Evidence and judgement

Inspect a current instruction at its point of use. Verify identity, revision and approval, then compare it with the actual task. Assess whether the chosen format remains readable and accessible. Appropriate metadata and approval evidence should support the decision, rather than create a parallel document bureaucracy.

Avoid this mistake

ISO 9001 does not impose a universal quality manual, six procedure model or fixed document hierarchy. Conversely, the absence of a named procedure requirement does not remove the need for information necessary to make the process effective.

Guidance referral

A.7.5 and A.2 clarify documented information. ISO 10013:2021 is a supporting referral for proportionate development and maintenance. [6]

7.5.3 Control availability integrity and history

Required outcome

Under 7.5.3.1, control information so it is suitable and available where and when needed and protected against relevant loss or misuse. Under 7.5.3.2, address distribution, access, retrieval, use, storage, preservation, legibility, changes, retention and disposition as applicable. Identify and control necessary external information. Protect evidence of conformity against unintended alteration. [1]

Practical translation

The control must preserve the ability to use the right information and to trust the history. A shared drive may provide access without controlling changes. A restricted system may protect confidentiality while preventing an authorised operator from obtaining the current instruction.

Application in the work

For a mobile asset record, retain authenticated access, current source document links and suitable authorisation to change evidence. Plan what the user should do when the network or record is unavailable. A local draft should not be mistaken for the authoritative approved record. The technical and security design needs assessment for the actual use.

Evidence and judgement

Test retrieval with an ordinary authorised user, review an obsolete version and examine how a completed evidence record is protected. Follow an external specification through a revision. Define retention using applicable business, customer and legal needs; ISO 9001 does not prescribe one period for every record.

Avoid this mistake

A QR label is a locator, not proof of permission, current equipment condition or compliant use. A backup is not a complete document control system. Do not destroy history merely to make the latest record look complete.

Guidance referral

A.7.5 explains formats, origins and history. ISO 10013 supports implementation; information security and privacy requirements need their own applicable assessment. [6]

Apply the clause across the team

These responsibilities are recommended applications for the reader groups. The organisation still determines its own roles, competence and authority.

Reader	Contribution	Useful output
IMS manager	Connect resources, competence and information controls to process effectiveness.	An account of capability gaps and supported authorisations.
Engineer	Evaluate technical fitness, measurement decisions and knowledge requirements.	Task criteria, suitability evidence and technically justified limits.
Leadership team	Provide the capability that accepted commitments require.	A resourced response to constraints and review of its actual effect.

Use it in an integrated management system

Resources and information commonly serve several management systems. Maintenance can affect quality capability, safety and environmental control. Authorisation can involve both technical competence and system permissions. Preserve the distinct evidence for each judgement; a quality certificate, a login right and a safety release answer different questions.

Connections that should remain visible

Related clause	Connection to this decision
Clauses 4 and 6	Context and planning define what capability is needed.
Clause 5	Leadership must provide needed resources and usable authority.
Clause 8	Support arrangements enable valid operating decisions.
Clauses 9 and 10	Evidence of weak capability informs evaluation and corrective action.

Engineering case The certificate and the tolerance

Fictional scenario for practical discussion

Fictional Calder Instruments uses a calibrated measuring device for a newly specified tolerance. The certificate is current, but nobody has reviewed whether its reported performance is suitable for the measurement decision under the actual conditions.

The engineer identifies the characteristic, range, tolerance, method, environment and relevant uncertainty. The review determines whether the available measurement process supports a defensible conformity decision. No universal accuracy ratio is assumed. Competent technical judgement and the applicable requirements determine the criteria.

If the resource is unsuitable, stop relying on it for that task, establish an appropriate alternative and assess any earlier results that may have been affected. The evidence should connect equipment identity, the suitability decision, the authorised method and the resulting action.

The case illustrates the distinction between having a certificate and demonstrating fitness for purpose. It does not provide a calibration method or replace competent metrological assessment.

Use the case with your team

Identify the applicable requirement, distinguish the observed facts from assumptions and decide what evidence would support the next action. Explain who has the authority and competence to make that decision. Discuss what would contradict your initial conclusion.

Your decision and the evidence still needed

Service case Knowledge without access

Fictional scenario for practical discussion

Fictional Merefield Review Services has moved its technical guidance into a controlled online library. A remote reviewer can open the process page but lacks permission to retrieve a necessary customer specification. An experienced colleague sends an older saved copy by email.

The problem crosses infrastructure, knowledge, communication and document control. Correcting the immediate permission can restore access, but the team must assess the work performed using the old copy and the controls that encouraged the workaround.

The IMS manager tests the user journey with an ordinary account. Engineering checks the affected criterion and result. Leadership addresses the capability or support constraint. Set a clear escalation condition when authoritative information cannot be obtained, and ensure that users understand it.

A successful administrator demonstration is not proof of availability to the person performing the work. The later verification should use the actual authorised role and relevant working conditions.

Use the case with your team

Identify the applicable requirement, distinguish the observed facts from assumptions and decide what evidence would support the next action. Explain who has the authority and competence to make that decision. Discuss what would contradict your initial conclusion.

Your decision and the evidence still needed

Audit the decision and plan the response

The following prompts are practical aids. Define the audit criteria and scope using the applicable requirements and the organisation’s own arrangements. A prompt in this table is not a separate mandatory ISO requirement.

Subject	Question to test	Weak signal
Resources	Can this task be performed with today’s available capability?	A budget or maintenance plan treated as proof of functioning capability.
Measurement	Why is this resource fit for this decision?	Calibration status confused with measurement suitability.
Competence	What demonstrates ability for the authorised task?	Attendance or a matrix used as the sole competence evidence.
Information	Can the ordinary user retrieve the current approved source?	Administrator access used to demonstrate universal availability.

A focused implementation discussion

1. Select a consequential task and its actual authorised user.
2. Check the people, infrastructure, conditions, measurement and knowledge needed.
3. Retrieve the controlling information using the ordinary working arrangement.
4. Record capability gaps, immediate limits and the evidence needed to close them.

Write a useful finding

Separate the criterion, what was observed and the resulting gap. Keep an improvement suggestion distinct from a nonconformity. Where immediate control is needed, use the appropriate operational authority rather than waiting for the audit report.

Record the next decision

Identify the responsible owner, the action or decision needed, the evidence of implementation and the test of effectiveness where relevant. Set timing proportionate to the issue. The organisation must determine what can proceed while uncertainty remains.

Task capability review

Reusable RPG worksheet for internal application

Complete for one defined process or decision. Reference supporting records rather than copying a whole report. The worksheet is a suggested method; its fields are not additional requirements.

1. Task output and acceptance requirement

2. Required people competence and authorisation

3. Infrastructure environment and measurement suitability

4. Knowledge and current information needed

5. Unavailable or unreliable capability and immediate response

6. Owner evidence and review of restored capability

Completion check: can another competent reviewer understand the basis, authority and limitations of the decision?

Measurement or information exception

Reusable RPG worksheet for internal application

Complete for one defined process or decision. Reference supporting records rather than copying a whole report. The worksheet is a suggested method; its fields are not additional requirements.

1. Resource document or record identity

2. Expected condition and observed exception

3. Potentially affected work and period

4. Technical and access authority involved

5. Immediate control retrospective assessment and action

6. Evidence of fitness or availability before further reliance

Completion check: can another competent reviewer understand the basis, authority and limitations of the decision?

References and publication information

Official publication records and public guidance checked on 8 November 2026. The referral notes identify scope and appropriate use; they are not full reviews of the supporting standards. Obtain the full publication where it is needed.

[1] ISO 9001:2026 Quality management systems Requirements
Primary clause basis: the supplied standard text and its informative Annex A. Open official record

[2] ISO/TS 9002:2016 Guidelines for the application of ISO 9001:2015
Earlier edition implementation guidance; check compatibility with 2026. Open official record

[3] ISO 9001 Auditing Practices Group
Supplementary audit papers, many for the 2015 edition. Open official record

[4] ISO 10015:2019 Competence management and people development
Guidance referral for establishing and improving competence. Open official record

[5] ISO 10012:2026 Requirements for measurement management systems
A separate requirements standard; not automatically required by ISO 9001. Open official record

[6] ISO 10013:2021 Guidance for documented information
Guidance referral for appropriate documented information. Open official record

[7] ISO 30401:2018 Knowledge management systems Requirements
A separate management system standard; check amendments and revision status. Open official record

[8] ISO 10018:2020 People engagement
Guidance referral for engagement in the QMS. Open official record

[9] ISO 9000:2026 Quality management Fundamentals and vocabulary
Normative vocabulary referral identified by ISO 9001. Open official record

[10] ISO 9000 Glossary Guidance on selected words 2025
Supporting language clarification. Use formal definitions where applicable. Open official record

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The task capability check

Practical prompts for applying the requirements. Read with the publication and the licensed standard.

01

People

Is the authorised person competent for this work?

02

Infrastructure

Are the required assets and systems functioning?

03

Conditions

Does the operating environment support conformity?

04

Measurement

Are the method and resources fit for the decision?

05

Knowledge

Can the necessary judgement be applied?

06

Information

Can the user obtain the current controlled source?

RPG recommended practice. These prompts do not add ISO requirements.

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A certificate is the start of a decision

Practical prompts for applying the requirements. Read with the publication and the licensed standard.

01
Identify

Connect the certificate to the actual resource.

02
Review

Understand the result and any limitations.

03
Compare

Assess suitability for the intended task and criterion.

04
Control

Maintain status and protection against invalidation.

05
Investigate

Assess affected earlier results when fitness fails.

06
Authorise

Record the appropriate decision and supporting evidence.

RPG recommended practice. These prompts do not add ISO requirements.

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